LECTURE 13 : CV AND COVER LETTER WRITING

Introduction

In the previous lesson we learnt about essay writing. In this lesson we are going to learn about CV and cover letter writing. CV is short for curriculum vitae and it is also referred to as a résumé. It is a write up detailing your academic achievement including skills and job experience. Your CV is a personal marketing document used to sell yourself to prospective employers. It should tell them about you, your professional history and your skills, abilities and achievements. Ultimately, it should highlight why you're the best person for the job.

A CV is required when applying for a job. In addition to your CV, employers may also require a cover letter and a completed application form.

Learning outcomes

By the end of the lesson, you should be able to:

i. *Explain what a CV is.*

ii. *Explain the main steps to follow when writing a CV.*

iii. *Write a good CV.*

What is a Curriculum Vitae?

Curriculum Vitae is a course of your life and it is a concise document which summarizes your past, existing professional skills, proficiency and experiences. The purpose of this document is to prove that you have the necessary skills and some complementary ones to do the job for which you are applying. You are basically selling your talents, skills and proficiencies through your cv. Your CV should take into consideration:

- Comprehensive list of academic qualifications and experiences.
- Usually several pages in length. (2-6)
- Presentation of information should reflect your focus
- Styles and norms. This varies from field to field

How does a Resume differ from a CV?

Resume

Most job hunters are familiar with resumes—they're designed to be short overviews of a candidate's background and experience.

- Resumes are much shorter and less detailed than CVs, and are typically used for non-academic, non-research based positions in the United States (in other countries across Europe, Asia, Africa, and the Middle East, CVs are often the norm when applying for jobs).
- Resumes are typically only about a page long, sometimes slightly more if you've been working for a long while or have an extremely varied job history. But unlike a CV, the goal of a resume is to be brief.
- A candidate's resume is typically tailored to the position she or he is looking for, and often contains an objective or summary statement along with one's education, experience, job-specific abilities and skills, and personal contact information.

CV

- A CV is typically a longer and more in-depth summary of a candidate's skill set and experience—it can run two to three pages or more, depending on the candidate and her or his background and accomplishments.
- Although CVs are widely used in a variety of fields in countries outside of the United States, in America they are typically utilized when applying for academic, scientific, medical, education, research, and international employment positions.
- CVs are also often utilized as part of funding applications, such as for grants and fellowships.
- Along with the usual information that you'd find on a resume, including education, experience, job-specific abilities and skills, and personal contact information, CVs include a candidate's teaching and research experience, publications, fellowships and
- grants, licenses, relevant professional associations and awards, as well as any other information that's relevant to the position being applying for.

Resume	CV
Emphasizes skills; It focuses more on practical skills, that is what is what you can do more than what you know.	Emphasizes academic accomplishments
Is no longer than 2 pages, with an additional page for publications and/or poster presentations if highly relevant to the job	Length depends upon experience and includes a complete list of publications, posters, and presentations
Used when applying for a position in industry, non-profit, and public sector	used when applying for positions in academia, fellowships and grants

Types of Curriculum Vitae

There are three main types of Curriculum Vitae and they include:

1. **Chronological CVs**

A chronological CV focuses on presenting the candidate's experience on an employer-by-employer basis, with the posts being listed in reverse chronological order. Chronological CVs should also contain a brief personal statement at the front which sets out the key skills and strengths of the candidate. This is the most common type of CV and it contains a brief personal statement at the front which set the skills and the strength of the candidate out. The chronological CV focuses on presenting the candidate's skills experience on an employer-by-employer basis, with the posts being listed in reverse chronological order. In our case, since you are fresh graduates with no working experiences, you have to highlights on your skills, that are the things you can do given the opportunity to work. This type of CV is not recommended for you as graduates who are yet to enter the job market but it is important for us to take note so we don't make any mistakes in the preparation of our CVs.

Advantages of chronological CVs are as follows:

- If you do not have many achievements, significant highlights or experiences across your career, taking a job-by-job approach can detail your main responsibilities and take the emphasis away from key achievements which is more expected in a functional CV
- Particularly useful for those applying within the same industry as it will demonstrate your career progression.

- For most employers, it is the best format for most employers because it simply identifies your skills, roles and responsibilities in each job

Disadvantages

- If you have gaps in your employment which you would rather not highlight, a chronological CV will make them more obvious
- If you are changing career direction, a chronological CV may not be so relevant to a recruiter who will be more concerned about the transferable skills that you are bringing rather than the detail of your experience in an unrelated sector

2. Skills-based CVs

The opposite of a chronological CV is a skills-based CV. The two defining characteristics are the inclusion of a statement of the carrier objective and a prominent extended skills section at the start of the CV, below your personal details. The statement of your career objective " lets your CV stand out," An example would be 'experienced biology researcher now seeking to use their skills in a science communication project'. The skills section should suit your specification of the job you're applying for. Details of your education and employment history are relegated to the second page, with only short descriptions highlighting your achievements.

Advantages

Makes career gaps less obvious, and it's easy for the recruiter to see why they should invite you to interview. You can also talk about more than one job under each skill subheading.

Disadvantages

This is a modern style, so you'll need to judge whether the organization you're applying to will look favourably upon it. I will cautions against this approach for traditional academic employers.

3. Combined CVs

To balance the benefits of the two approaches, Jones says the safest approach for early-career scientists is to use a hybrid approach. Leave a chronological list of your education and employment history on the first page, but include a medium-sized skills section on the second page.

Whatever type of CV you choose, remember to adapt the content to match the person specification of the role in question. “For every job you apply for, you have to create a completely new CV,”

Writing an impressive CV: Features of a good CV

Following are important details to consider when writing a CV:

1. Personal details: name, professional title and contact details

The first part of your CV, positioned at the top of the page, should contain your name, professional title and contact details. Under no circumstances should you title your CV with ‘curriculum vitae’ or ‘CV’ as it’s a waste of valuable space. Treat your name as the title instead.

When it comes to your contact details, your postal and email address and phone number(s) are essential, for example:

Surname first, then other names/Professional Title
P.O. Box, Location: Town, County
Phone: 0721000000
Email: name@example.com

2. Personal Profile

A personal profile, also known as a personal statement, career objective and professional profile, is one of the most important aspects of your CV. It’s a short paragraph that sits just underneath your name and contact details giving prospective employers an overview of who you are and what you’re all about.

You should tailor your profile to every job you apply for

- Highlight specific qualities that match you to the role.
- Aim to keep your personal statement short and sweet, and no longer than a few sentences. Answer the following questions:

1. Who are you?
2. What can you offer the company?
3. What are your career goals?

As a general rule, the most important information should be at the top of the first page. Remember that a recruiter spends a very short amount of time scanning your CV. That means that on the first half of page you need a high-impact profile, containing the relevant key words for your industry and sector, also include some information about your current (or most relevant) job or qualification.

3. Education Background: In this section you give the dates and institution you attended, followed by the qualifications and grades you attained.

Like your experience section, your education should be listed in reverse chronological order, starting with most recent educational achievement, your degree, diploma, KACE, KCSE or GCSEs (or equivalents). Here is sample summary:

Institution	**Qualification**	**Dates (from-to-)**	**Grade Attained**
Karatina University	BCP	2015-2019	2nd Class Honours
Uthiru High School	K.C.S.E.	2011-2014	Grade A-
Orshwal Pry School	K.C.P.E	2007-2010	412maks

- Research project

If you have a degree, you could list a few of the most relevant modules, assignments or projects underneath.

For professionals that are a little further along in their careers, or have many certificates in their repertoire, you can lay your qualifications out in this way:

4. Skills: experience and Employment History

Your employment history section gives you a chance to outline your previous jobs, internships and work experience.

List your experience in reverse chronological order as your recent role is the most relevant to the employer .e.g.

2015 to date

2010- 2015

When listing each position of employment:

- State your job title,
- The employer
- The dates you worked and a line that summarizes the role.
- Then bullet-point your key responsibilities, skills and achievements.

It helps to choose the duties most relevant to the job you're applying for, especially if it's a long list. If you have many years' worth of experience, you can reduce the detail of old or irrelevant roles. If you have positions from more than 10 years' ago

Eg

mmm yyyy – mmm yyyy
Company Name, Location
Role Title
Outline
xxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxx

Key responsibilities

- xxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxx

Key achievements/projects

- xxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxx

Additional sections

There is a range of additional sections that may strengthen your CV and highlight your skills. Here are just a few you can include if you have room:

- **Key skills:** If you're writing a functional CV, or have some abilities you want to show off to the employer immediately, insert a key skills section underneath your personal profile. You should aim to detail four to five abilities at most.
- **Hobbies and interests:** If you feel that your CV is lacking, you can boost your document by inserting a hobbies and interests section at the end. Draw on interests that make you stand out or are relevant to the job.

Membership to Professional Organizations
AMWIK-Association of Media Women in Kenya
CPA Kenya
EACA-East African Communication Association
PRSK-Public Relations Society of Kenya

Consultancies

References:

Have 2 or 3 referees

Formatting and spacing guidelines

Formatting and spacing your CV is equally as important as the content.
Here are some formatting and spacing tips to bear in mind:

Length: The standard length of a CV in Kenya is two pages. However, one size doesn't fit all. It depends on your experience; UNESCO and World Bank require a maximum 4 pages.
Headings: Each section must be introduced by a big, bold heading to ensure an easy read.
Font type: Most employers will receive your CV in a digital format, so choose a clear font like Calibri or Arial. You can use a different font type for your headings, but keep it professional and easy-to-read too.
Many hiring managers rank Arial and Calibri highly. In fact, Calibri also has the added advantage of being the default Microsoft Word font.
In Kenya, many organizations recommend Times New Roman

Font size and page margins: The body of your CV should be between 12 point font, and your headings between 14 and 18 points. Keep your page margins around 2.5cm, but never reduce them to less than 1.27cm or your CV will appear cluttered and hard to read.
Proofreading and consistency: Your formatting must be consistent throughout your CV. Don't spoil your polished look by including typos and inaccuracies.

Keep a generic copy of your CV for your own records, but if you're applying for a specific job, it must be tailored to the role.

Saving the file

Save your CV as a PDF file to ensure recruiters can open it on any device. A pdf will also maintain formatting, so you can be sure that employers will see your CV as you intended.

Next steps

Your CV is your chance to make a great first impression and secure yourself an interview, so follow this 2019 guide and then upload your CV to apply for your next job. Three Referees who are:

- People who are your mentors
- People above your level, your supervisor at work etc.
- Credible people who know you well, no politicians and relatives

WRITING A COVER LETTER

Introduction

Your CV details your skills, history and experience. Your cover letter, on the other hand, is the first bit of information the employer or recruiter will come into contact with before they read the CV. They will be looking to see how you sell yourself and if you have the right skill set for the job.

What is a cover letter?

Cover letters are the first chance you have in impressing your employers. It is a type of letter that explains the contents of another document or a CV. It explains your purpose for writing an application for a job placement and also highlights a few of your experiences and skills and request for an opportunity to personally meet with you prospective employers. Note that every CV should be accompanied by a cover letter.

NOTE: While your CV details all of your relevant experience, your cover letter should be specific to the job itself. It needs to reference the job description, job title and name of the company you are applying for. What's more, you need to address it to the relevant head of department, if you can find their details.

Types of Cover Letter

There are three main types of cover letters:

1. Application Cover letters: this is a letter written to respond to an open vacancy that has been advertised or recommended to you. It should be formatted professionally and must include good salutations and closings. Include in the letter your specific skills in relation to what, the employers are looking for.
2. Prospecting Cover Letters: this is letter to show interest in a company that you want to work with. It details your interest in the area of work you are looking for.
3. Networking Cover Letters: this type of letter functions as introductory, referral and network letters. Such letters seek to recommend you to a company based on past experience you have had with other employers.

Guidelines in Writing a good Cover Letter

Your cover letter is going to do the initial selling for you. You'll need to show how your skills are aligned to the job, the passion you have for the role and company and what value you can add. All while letting your personality shine through.

A good cover letter should complement your CV and communicate your core qualifications and experiences that are relevant to the job you're applying for.
To give yourself the best possible chance to land an interview, your cover letter needs to highlight your unique selling points and the qualities that set you apart from the rest.
Carefully select the content you want to include. Choose points from your CV that are most relevant to the recruiter and expand on them. By putting forward a relevant, compelling argument, you're sure to convince the hiring manager that you're the best candidate for the job.
The following are some guidelines to writing effective cover letters:

1. Address the letter correctly

Whether you've seen the role being advertised on a job board like CV-Library, or a business focused platform like LinkedIn, it's important to address the hiring manager correctly. Just remember this is your first opportunity to make a good impression.

It doesn't need to be overly formal, but it shouldn't be too casual either. The most common way to address your letter would be:

The Human Resource Manager,
Company Name
P.O Box….
Dear Sir/Madam

2. Introduce yourself

Give your letter context by starting with your name and the role you're applying for. Mention that you feel ready for a new challenge and what appeals to you about the job and company.

It's here that there might be an opportunity for your personality to shine through. Showing passion can really help your covering letter stand out from the crowd.
It's important to do some preliminary research into the company. Be sure to read its mission statement and values. This will help you when mentioning why you want to be part of their organization.

3. Highlight 3-5 skills

A well-written cover letter should be tailored to the job specification.

Ensure what you've selected to highlight is highly relevant. That way, you can instantly show that your skills and experience are an ideal match. The idea is to intrigue the reader enough to give your CV a read over and schedule a phone interview with you.

Pick 3-5 skills from the job requirement list and write a paragraph worth per skill.

Here's an example:

Skill: PR communication experience
In a previous role I gained good PR communications experience. I was in charge of 10 small brands and my responsibility was to pitch their products to journalists, build press relationships with those in the industry and ensure coverage in well-respected publications.

4. Use numbers to show results

Don't be afraid to show-off the best work you've done in your career, as long as it's relevant. If you've managed to increase marketing leads through a campaign, rebrand an entire portfolio of products or grown sales leads month on month, then say it – and preferably with numbers.

Being able to show any employer that you have a basic understanding of reporting can put you at an advantage over other candidates. It shows you're business driven, everything you do can be tracked and measured and that you're a results-driven worker.

5. Don't mention what you're missing

Today's job market is difficult, the job skills needed for roles is ever increasing!

You can show the employer or recruiter that you're somebody who is a quick thinker, picks up skills effortlessly and is easy to communicate with, then these soft skills will help you progress to interview stage.

Many technical skills can be learned on the job. So, sometimes it's more important to have a person with a positive, can-do attitude, who has what it takes to be successful in the role long-term.

6. You should leave a single line's space between each paragraph of your cover letter, between your contact details and introductory paragraph, and between your closing remarks

and name or signature. If you are submitting a printed cover letter, you should leave enough space between your closing remarks and typed name to include a handwritten signature.

7. Look out for grammar mistakes

Be careful with grammar, as this can get you in the 'no' pile rather quickly. When putting together a well-written cover letter, it's extremely important to read, re-read and have someone else proof it (and your CV). It's easy to overlook simple mistakes when you've been working on something for a long time.

How you close your cover letter is arguably the most important part, as it's your final words that will leave a lasting impression with the reader.

Create a compelling closing statement that ends on a positive note by highlighting the key points within your cover letter.

Here are three ways in which you can close your cover letter to help land you that interview.

1) Emphasize your enthusiasm for the job role

You want to portray your passion for the job role and for the company itself by showing you are keen to start contributing your skills.

Aim to illustrate how you will fit into the company culture and how your character and work ethics is just what they are looking for. This will show that you are confident in your abilities, that you have put genuine effort into your cover letter and that you are excited for the opportunity to work at the company.

An example of this is: 'I am excited for the opportunity to offer my strengths, skills and professional expertise in this industry, to benefit your company and to thrive in this role.'

2) Reiterate how your experience and qualifications will benefit the employer

Enthusiasm, combined with relevant experience and qualifications, is a strong combination.

You want to make it clear how the employer will benefit from what you have to offer.

For example, if the job specification, mentions that they need someone with strong computer skills or someone with previous experience in copywriting, then take this as your chance to sell your successes and achievements in relation to the role.

An example of this is: 'I believe my professional skills (give examples) and personal values (give examples) align with your company and have prepared me to be a successful contributing team member in a company exactly like yours'

3) Summary

In this topic we have leant that a CV serves the purpose of introducing you to your prospective employer long before they invite you for the job interview. It is therefore important to write a good CV suitable for the position that you are seeking in that organization. All the necessary details must be included, they include; personal details, personal profile, education background, additional skills and achievements attained after school and three referees.

The CV should be accompanied by a cover letter. Although the cover letter in a way summarizes what is in your CV, it briefly highlights training and experiences relevant to the job that you are applying for. It should also be neat and in the correct format; your address, the recipient's address, salutation, reference, body and conclusion.

Style and Content in Writing a Cover Letter

- ✓ Avoid cover letter templates.
- ✓ Make your cover letter your own.
- ✓ Be honest and don't exaggerate.
- ✓ Put yourself in the shoes of your employers.
- ✓ Use employers' language.
- ✓ Avoid personal pronouns (I, we) and articles (a, the). Use action verbs, measurable results and quantify.
- ✓ Use parallel grammar and minimal punctuation.
- ✓ Aim for a tightly constructed, succinct, and efficient presentation.

Activities

1. Imagine that you have come across a job advertisement in a certain organization. Write a detailed CV that you intend to send as you apply for the job in the organization.
2. Write a cover letter to accompany your CV for the said job application in 1 above.

3. Explain the main features of a memo, circular and notice.